

Smirity Kaushik

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Research interests

My research sits at the intersection of usable security and privacy, AI safety, and technology policy. I use qualitative and quantitative methods to develop actionable design and policy solutions that improve people's experiences with emerging technologies.

Education

- 2025 **Ph.D. in Information Sciences**, University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign
- 2019 **M.S. in Information Management**, Syracuse University, School of Information Studies
- 2017 **Bachelor of Laws – B.A. LL.B., (U.S. J.D. equivalent)**, University of Delhi, Faculty of Law
- 2014 **B.A.(H) History**, University of Delhi, Lady Shri Ram College

Employments

- 2025 - present **Postdoctoral Research Associate**
The George Washington University - Dept of Computer Science | Washington DC, United States
- 2023 - 2024 **Visiting Research Scholar**
Max Planck Institute for Security and Privacy | Bochum, Germany
- 2021 - 2025 **Graduate Student Research Assistant**
University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign, School of Information Sciences | Champaign, IL, United States
- 2019 - 2021 **Data Protection and Privacy Consultant**
Ernst & Young | San Francisco, CA, United States
- 2017 - 2019 **Graduate Student Research Assistant**
Syracuse University, School of Information Studies | Syracuse, NY, United States

Publications

Conferences are the top-tier academic publishing venues in computer science and information science (CS/IS). Thus, the majority of my research is published in CS/IS conference proceedings.

** co-first authorship.*

Journal (Heavily Peer-reviewed)

- [J1] **“Every Website Is a Puzzle!”: Facilitating Access to Common Website Features for People with Visual Impairments**
Natã M Barbosa, Jordan Hayes, Smirity Kaushik, Yang Wang
ACM Transactions on Accessible Computing (TACCESS) (15), 1-35. 2022.
<https://dl.acm.org/doi/pdf/10.1145/3519032>

- [J2] **Privacy Perceptions and Behaviors Towards Targeted Advertising on Social Media: A Cross-Country Study**
Smirity Kaushik, Tanusree Sharma, Yaman Yu, Amna F. Ali, Bart P. Knijnenburg, Yang Wang, Yixin Zou
 Proceedings on Privacy Enhancing Technologies (PoPETs). 2025.
<https://petsymposium.org/popets/2025/popets-2025-0057.pdf>
 Conference Proceedings (Heavily Peer-reviewed)
- [C10] **“You Have Been Selected as the Winner”: Characterizing User-Reported Scams on TikTok**
Smirity Kaushik, Kyle Beadle, Gauri Nayak, Madelyn R. Sanfilippo, Mainack Mondal, Sai T. Peddinti, Yang Wang, Jingjie Li, Yixin Zou
 Symposium on Usable Privacy and Security (SOUPS). 2026.
- [C9] **It Shouldn’t Be This Difficult: Researcher Perspectives on Diversity and Inclusion in Usable Privacy and Security Research**
 Priyasha Chatterjee, Smirity Kaushik, Karola Marky, Yixin Zou
 ACM Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI). 2026.
- [C8] **Governing Manipulative and Synthetic Content on Social Media Platforms**
Smirity Kaushik, Madelyn R. Sanfilippo
 Hawaii International Conference on System Sciences (HICSS). 2026.
- [C7] **Design and evaluation of inclusive email security indicators for people with visual impairments**
 Yaman Yu, Saidivya Ashok, Smirity Kaushik, Yang Wang, Gang Wang
 IEEE Symposium on Security and Privacy (SP). 2023.
<https://ieeexplore.ieee.org/abstract/document/10179407>
- [C6] **User perceptions and experiences of targeted ads on social media platforms: Learning from Bangladesh and India**
 Tanusree Sharma*, Smirity Kaushik*, Yaman Yu*, Syed Ishtiaque Ahmed, Yang Wang
 ACM Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI). 2023.
<https://dl.acm.org/doi/abs/10.1145/3544548.3581498>
- [C5] **ImageAlly: A Human-AI Hybrid Approach to Support Blind People in Detecting and Redacting Private Image Content**
 Zhuohao Jerry Zhang, Smirity Kaushik, JooYoung Seo, Haolin Yuan, Sauvik Das, Leah Findlater, Danna Gurari, Abigale Stangl, Yang Wang
 Symposium on Usable Privacy and Security (SOUPS). 2023.
<https://www.usenix.org/system/files/soups2023-zhang.pdf>
- [C4] **GuardLens: Supporting Safer Online Browsing for People with Visual Impairments**
Smirity Kaushik, Natã M Barbosa, Yaman Yu, Tanusree Sharma, Zachary Kilhoffer, JooYoung Seo, Sauvik Das, Yang Wang
 Symposium on Usable Privacy and Security (SOUPS). 2023.
<https://www.usenix.org/system/files/soups2023-kaushik.pdf>

- [C3] **“How I Know For Sure”: People’s Perspectives on Solely Automated Decision-Making(SADM)** 

Smirity Kaushik, Yaxing Yao, Pierre Dewitte, Yang Wang
Symposium on Usable Privacy and Security (SOUPS). 2021.
<https://www.usenix.org/system/files/soups2021-kaushik.pdf>
SOUPS IAPP Privacy Award.

Defending my castle: A co-design study of privacy mechanisms for smart homes

- [C2] Yaxing Yao, Justin Reed Basdeo, Smirity Kaushik, Yang Wang
ACM Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI). 2019.
<https://dl.acm.org/doi/pdf/10.1145/3290605.3300428>

- [C1] **Cooperative privacy and security: Learning from people with visual impairments and their allies** 

Jordan Hayes, Smirity Kaushik, Charlotte Emily Price, Yang Wang
Symposium on Usable Privacy and Security (SOUPS). 2019.
<https://www.usenix.org/system/files/soups2019-hayes.pdf>
SOUPS IAPP Privacy Award.

Workshops and Panels Co-organized

- [WP1] **Workshop on Inclusive Privacy and Security**

Taslima Akter, Kevin Butler, Joe Calandrino, Lynne Coventry, Sanchari Das, Roberto Hoyle, Smirity Kaushik, Ada Lerner, Abigail Marsh, Imani N. S. Munyaka, Lucy Qin, Shruti Sannon, Yang Wang, Noel Warford, Yaxing Yao, Tanusree Sharma,
Symposium on Usable Privacy and Security (SOUPS). 2015 - 2024.

Workshop Papers (Lightly Peer-reviewed)

- [W4] **Governing Manipulative and Synthetic Content on Video-based Social media Platforms**
Smirity Kaushik, Madelyn R. Sanfilippo
6th Annual Symposium on Applications of Contextual Integrity. 2024.

- [W3] **Governing Manipulative and Synthetic Content on Video-based Social media Platforms**
Smirity Kaushik, Madelyn R. Sanfilippo
6th Annual Symposium on Applications of Contextual Integrity. 2024.

- [W2] **Cross-Country Examination of People’s Experience with Targeted Advertising on Social Media**

Smirity Kaushik, Tanusree Sharma, Yaman Yu, Amna F. Ali, Yang Wang, Yixin Zou
ACM Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI) Late-Breaking Work. 2024.

- [W1] **Enabling Privacy by Design in GDPR: An Analysis of Industry Tool Support**

Smirity Kaushik, Yang Wang
CHI Workshop on General Data Protection Regulation. 2018.

Technical Reports

- [T1] **Copyright and Artificial Intelligence (AI)**
Gowri Saini Balasubramaniam, Sara Rachel Benson, Anita Say Chan, Keith Jacobs, Karen V Jenkins, Smirity Kaushik, Jiaqi Ma, Madelyn Rose Sanfilippo, Eryclis Rodrigues Bezerra Silva, Emmy Tither, Michael Twidale, Ted E Underwood, Yaman Yu, Kyrie Zhou
Public comments submitted to the US Copyright Office via the notice of inquiry on “Copyright and Artificial Intelligence (AI)”. 2023.
<https://www.ideals.illinois.edu/items/128265/bitstreams/428897/data.pdf>

Honors & Awards

- 2025 **Lightning Talks Speaker Award**
Awarded 2nd best speaker award and cash prize at the Postdoc Appreciation Day, GW
- 2024 **NSF Student Travel Award**
Awarded financial support to attend the PrivaCI 2024 symposium.
- 2024 **Gary Marsden Travel Award**
Awarded financial support to attend the CHI 2024 conference.
- 2024 **President’s Research in Diversity Travel Assistance Award**
Awarded travel assistance to attend the CHI 2024 conference.
- 2023 **Computing Research Association (CRA) Grad Cohort Workshop for Women Scholar**
Awarded a scholarship to attend CRA Grad Cohort Workshop for Women Scholars
- 2021 **IAPP Privacy award**
For “*How I Know For Sure*”: *People’s Perspectives on Solely Automated Decision-Making(SADM)*.
- 2021 **Google CS Research Mentorship Program Mentee (CSRMP 2021)**
Received career and research mentorship from a Googler Mentor for a quarter.
- 2019 **John R. Weitzel Memorial Award Scholar for Information Systems Research**
Awarded by Syracuse University, iSchool, to the top graduate student for demonstrating excellence in the area of information systems through coursework and research.
- 2019 **IAPP Privacy award**
For *Cooperative privacy and security: Learning from people with visual impairments and their allies*.
- 2018 **Grace Hopper Conference 2018 (GHC’18) Scholar**
Awarded full scholarship to attend the world’s largest conference of women in computing.

Funding

Grants

- 2024 **Google Academic Research Award on Trust & Safety: Safeguarding Emerging Adults from Scams on Short-Form Video Platforms**
Co-PI with Yixin Zou (PI, Max Planck Institute for Security and Privacy), Mainack Mondal (Co-PI, Indian Institute of Technology, Kharagpur). \$100,000.

- 2021 **Meta Research Award: Global South Citizens' Privacy Perceptions and Management of Targeted Ads on Social Media.**
Co-PI with Yang Wang (PI, University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign), Tanusree Sharma (Co-PI, University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign), Yaman Yu (Co-PI, University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign). \$100,000.

Fellowships

- 2024-25 **Provost Match Fellowship**
Awarded by University of Illinois Urbana Champaign, Graduate College, to conduct dissertation research.
- 2017 **Information Management Faculty Engagement Scholar (IMFES) fellowship**
Awarded by Syracuse University, iSchool, to conduct research under the mentorship of a faculty member.

Teaching Experience

Co-Instructor

- Fall 2025 **CSCI 4533/6533 Introduction to Usable Security and Privacy**, Dept. of Computer Science, The George Washington University

Graduate Student Instructor

- Summer 2025 **IS 400: iSchool Colloquium series**, University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign
- Fall 2023 **IS 236: User Research & Evaluation**, University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign

Guest Lectures

- 2025 **Introduction to Usable Security and Privacy** (1 lecture)
CS1010 Computer Science Orientation, Dept. of Computer Science, The George Washington University
- 2025 **Targeted advertising and privacy in cross-cultural settings** (1 lecture)
IS 400: iSchool Colloquium series, University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign
- 2024 **Inclusive privacy in the age of emerging technologies** (1 lecture)
IS 226: Introduction to Human-Computer Interaction (HCI), University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign
- 2023 **How to conduct online surveys? A case study** (1 lecture)
IS 236: User Research & Evaluation | University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign

Mentoring

- 2025 Adryana Hutchinson (Ph.D., The George Washington University)
- 2025 Jialiang Yan (Ph.D., The George Washington University)
- 2025 Monica Kodwani (Ph.D., The George Washington University)
- 2025 Junho Eum (Ph.D., The George Washington University)
- 2025 Meira Gilbert (Ph.D., University of Washington)

- 2024 Emmanuel Tweneboah (Master's, Ruhr University, Bochum, Germany)
- 2024 Mindy Tran (Ph.D., Max Planck Institute for Security and Privacy, Bochum, Germany)
- 2023 Gauri Nayak (Master's, University of Washington → Ph.D., Cornell University)
- 2021 Yaman Yu (Ph.D., UIUC)
- 2021 Zhuohao (Jerry) Zhang (Master's, UIUC → Ph.D., University of Washington)
- 2018 J.R. Basdeo (undergraduate, Syracuse University)
- 2018 Megha Jakhotia (Master's, Syracuse University → Product Security Architect, Bloomberg)

Service

Paper Chair

- 2023 Workshop on Inclusive Privacy and Security: Paper Chair with Imani N. S. Munyaka
- 2022 Workshop on Inclusive Privacy and Security: Paper Chair with Taslima Akter

Program Committee Member

- 2026 Symposium On Usable Privacy and Security (SOUPS)
- 2026 Privacy Enhancing Technologies Symposium (PETS)
- 2026 ACM SIGACCESS Conference on Computers and Accessibility (ASSETS)
- 2026 ACM Conference on Human Factors in Computing (CHI) Student Mentoring Program: Dissertation Research Roundtable track
- 2026 ACM Conference on Human Factors in Computing (CHI) Posters
- 2024, 2025 BuildSEC'25, co-sponsored by the IEEE Society on Social Implications of Technology (SSIT)
- 2024 ACM Computer Supported Cooperative Work and Social Computing (CSCW) Posters

Conference Organizing and Volunteering

- 2026 SOUPS Workshop Co-Chair
- 2024-25 PETS Social Media Chair
- 2024 PETS Stipend Committee Member
- 2023-24 PrivaCI Student Volunteer
- 2024 CHI Student Volunteer
- 2021 SOUPS Student Volunteer
- 2021 CHI Student Volunteer

External Reviewer

- Privacy Enhancing Technologies Symposium (PETS)
- ACM Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI)
- ACM Conference on Computer-Supported Cooperative Work and Social Computing (CSCW)
- IEEE Security and Privacy (S&P)
- Symposium for Usable Privacy and Security (SOUPS)
- ACM Conference on Fairness, Accountability, and Transparency (FAccT)
- ACM Conversational User Interface (CUI)
- International Journal of Human-Computer Studies (IJHCS)
- BuildSEC'25, co-sponsored by the IEEE Society on Social Implications of Technology (SSIT)

Invited External Talks

- 2026 **Representational and Social Bias in Text to Image models**
Capital-Area Colloquium on Trustworthy and Usable Security/Privacy, CACTUS/P 2026, George Mason's "Mason Square" campus, Arlington, VA (May 08)
- 2026 **Privacy and Safety on Social Media: A Global Perspective**
Usable Privacy in Digital Age, Department of Information Sciences and Technology, George Mason University (Mar 17)
- 2026 **Trust and Safety on Social Media: Human-centered Insights and Governance Gaps**
HCI Seminar, Dept. of Computer Science, The Johns Hopkins University (Feb 24)
- 2025 **Characterizing User-Reported Scams on TikTok**
Capital-Area Colloquium on Trustworthy and Usable Security/Privacy, CACTUS/P 2025, College Park, MD (Dec 18)
- 2025 **Designing Human-Centered Security and Privacy Solutions for Diverse Users**
Usable Security and Privacy, Barnard College (Oct 15)
- 2025 **Targeted advertising and privacy in cross-cultural settings**
Google Privacy Sandbox UXR Team, Momentum Series (Jan 22)
- 2024 **Inclusive privacy in the age of emerging technologies**
Law & Tech Lab at Maastricht University, Netherlands (Jul 04)
- 2023 **Supporting Safer Online Browsing for People with Visual Impairments**
Sparkling Science speaker series | Max Planck Institute for Security and Privacy (MPI-SP) (Jun 15)

References

Dr. Yang Wang, Professor
School of Information Sciences, University of Illinois Urbana Champaign
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Dr. Adam Aviv, Professor
The George Washington University
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Dr. Yixin Zou, Tenure-track Faculty
Max Planck Institute for Security and Privacy
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